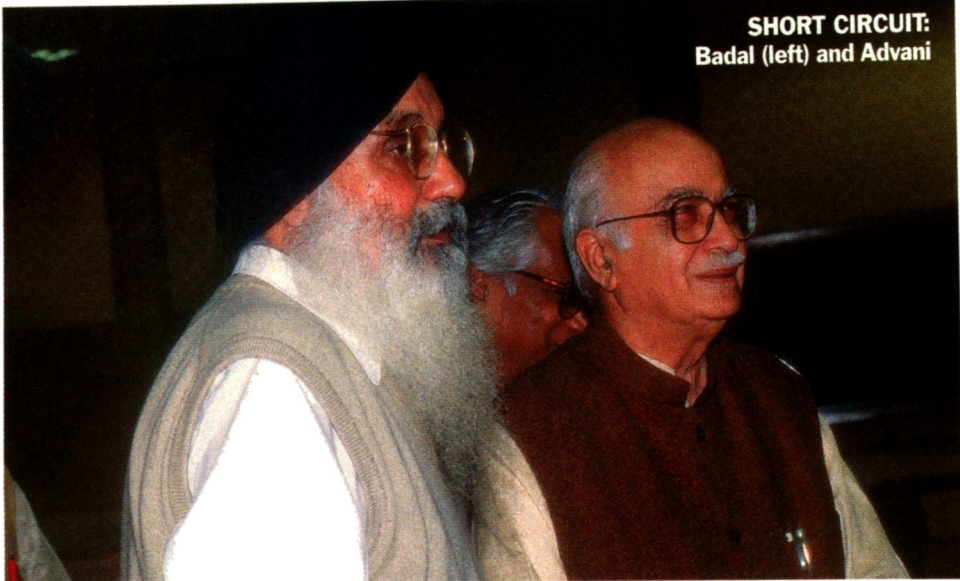


SHORT CIRCUIT:
Badal (left) and Advani



PUSHKARNA PRAMOD

Coalition Compulsions

CHANDIGARH Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's strong disapproval of subsidies notwithstanding, it's business as usual in Punjab where populism is again the flavour of the festive season. In yet another populist dole at the expense of a cash-strapped state exchequer,

the Parkash Singh Badal Government has rolled back power tariff hike for domestic consumers, yielding to relentless pressure from its ally—BJP. The state Government will now have to foot the bill for an additional subsidy of Rs 292 crore to offset the increased tariff

slab for the domestic sector announced by the state Power Regulatory Authority three months ago.

While the farm sector already gets free power worth Rs 2,400 crore every year, this is the first time that domestic and industrial consumers have been gifted an across-the-board power subsidy—a step that has inflated the annual subsidy bill to a

whopping Rs 4,300 crore.

Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) was initially reluctant to provide subsidy to domestic consumers but the issue snowballed into a major irritant between the coalition partners. Balbir Punj, party secretary in-charge of BJP in the state, did some hectic parleys and forced Badal to concede the demand on footing the bill on tariff hike and said this was necessary in the overall context of "course correction" in power sharing. Badal was left with little option after L.K. Advani and Rajnath Singh supported Punj's stand.

While BJP has a reason to gloat over having extracted a concession from Badal, state Finance Minister Manpreet Singh Badal's call to freeze the subsidies remains a cry in the wilderness, with both SAD and BJP caring two hoots about their debilitating impact on the state finances. **by Ramesh Vinayak**

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Marxist hearts bleed for the poor toiling masses but are not entirely insensitive to corporate India. A senior Left leader who was part of the team that negotiated with the Maoists in Nepal is now India Inc's main lobbyist in Kathmandu.

VOICES



"Gandhiji told us never to tell a lie and yet many among us begin our innings in the Congress with a lie."

Rahul Gandhi, Congress general secretary

Instead of creating a framework for education in Gujarat, (Narendra) Modi has set up an infrastructure of terror. He is the biggest showman of the country."

Kapil Sibal, Union minister for science and technology

"The Government came to us too late and without any sincerity. They only want to save themselves, not the (nuclear) deal. Their approaching us is of no consequence."

L.K. Advani, leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha

"If the founding fathers of our Constitution believed sports was just an amusement then it's hardly surprising that we have not given sports much importance."

Mani Shankar Aiyar, Union sports minister

"If an actor doesn't do well, 10,000 families are affected. It's a massive food chain of producer, director, writer, distributor, people who sell popcorn at theatres and the audience."

Salman Khan, actor

